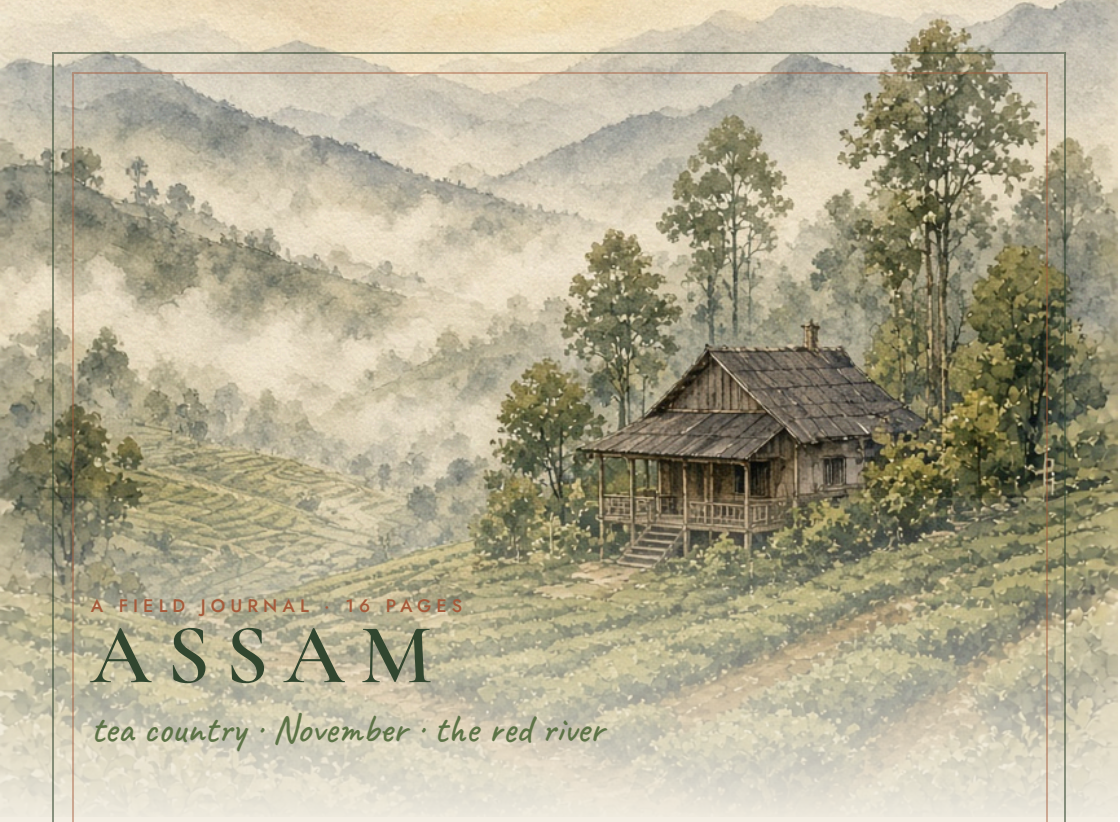


A FIELD JOURNAL · 16 PAGES

ASSAM

tea country · November · the red river

TRAVELLER

DATES

VISAKHAPATNAM → BHUBANESWAR → GUWAHATI → DURRUNG

Three nights, The Postcard in the Durrung Tea Estate, Tezpur. Pickup from GAU · ~216 km · ~4 hours. Kaziranga through the estate.

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NOVEMBER

Mornings ~12°C
Afternoons ~25°C
Park newly open
26.7162°N 92.7278°E

নমস্কাৰ · *in the land of the red river and blue hills*

MAPS

India, then the Northeast

Assam sits in the far north-east of the country, joined to the rest of India by a narrow corridor. The maps here are watercolour, schematic — not for navigation. They are to place you.



India. The boxed terracotta wash is the Northeast.



Seven Sisters: Assam in the river valley; Arunachal to the north; Meghalaya the plateau south; Nagaland and Manipur east; Mizoram further south; Tripura south-west. Sikkim is often counted as the eighth.

I FOUND MYSELF ON THIS MAP WHEN

THIS JOURNEY

Assam

A long east–west valley, a great river through the middle, hills on both rims. You land at Guwahati, on the south bank in the west, then drive east-north to Tezpur and Durrung. Kaziranga lies on the south bank, a morning's outing from the estate.



Guwahati	West. GAU. South bank. The city you fly into.
Tezpur / Durrung	North bank. Your stay. ~4 hours from the airport.
Kaziranga	South bank, east of Tezpur. UNESCO. One-horned rhino.
Nameri	North of Durrung, toward Arunachal. Jia Bharali river.
Brahmaputra	The pale river on the map. You will cross it, or drive beside it.

THE ROAD FROM THE AIRPORT SHOWED

A NOTE

Geography and culture

Assam is about 78,400 square kilometres: the wide Brahmaputra valley, the smaller Barak valley in the south, and two hill districts — Karbi Anglong and Dima Hasao. Nearly two-fifths of the state can flood. That is not a disaster footnote. Flood is how this land was made, and how Kaziranga still works.

People here call the place Axom. The old phrase is "the land of the red river and the blue hills." Assamese is the link language; Bodo, Mishing, Karbi, Dimasa and many others are spoken too, and so are the languages of the tea-garden communities. Hindu Vaishnavite satras — monasteries of Sankardev's faith — sit beside namghars, mosques, churches and indigenous shrines. A xorai (bell-metal offering stand) and a gamosa (the red-and-white towel) are the two objects you will see again and again.

Food is lighter than much of India: rice, fish, greens, a sour note (tenga) and an alkaline one (khar). Hospitality is a greeting — *bhaat khaisa ne?* means have you eaten? Accept tea when it is offered. Fold your hands for **নমস্কাৰ**.

HOLD IN MIND

Valley, not hill station.
River first, then forest, then tea.
Many peoples, one guest-right.
Silk, bamboo, and the gamosa.

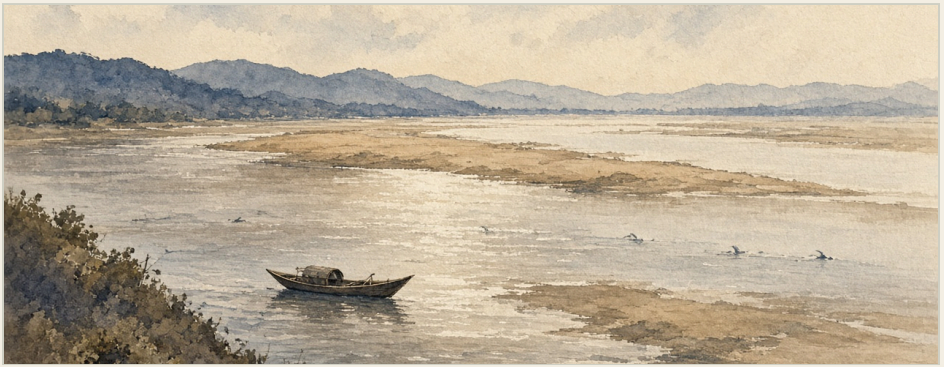
NOVEMBER HERE

Clear, dry, cool mornings.
Kati Bihu has just passed.
Parks are open.
Tea is in its late season.

WHAT CULTURE FELT LIKE, ON THE GROUND

THE RED RIVER · LUIT

Brahmaputra



It is born as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet, becomes the Siang or Dihang in Arunachal, the Brahmaputra in Assam, and the Jamuna in Bangladesh. About 2,900 kilometres from glacier to Bay of Bengal. In Assam it is a moving country: sandbars, chars, and Majuli, one of the world's great river islands.

The water often looks pale with silt — hence "red river." It feeds the beels of Kaziranga, the dolphins of the river, the paddy, and the fear of June. From the Tezpur side you may cross on the Kolia Bhomora bridge. Watch how wide it is. That width is the story.

FIRST SIGHT OF THE RIVER

COLOUR, BOATS, BIRDS, THE FAR BANK

National parks

Assam's official list has seven national parks. You are going to one of them. Nameri is the neighbour of Durrung, if a spare morning appears.

Kaziranga	UNESCO. One-horned rhino, elephant, wild buffalo, swamp deer, tiger. Your safari.
Manas	UNESCO. Himalayan foothills, west. Tiger, pygmy hog, golden langur.
Nameri	Sonitpur, by Arunachal. Jia Bharali rafting, hornbill, tiger. Close to the estate.
Orang	North bank. A smaller rhino landscape, sometimes called a mini-Kaziranga.
Dibru-Saikhowa	Riverine, east. Maguri beel, feral horses, winter birds.
Dehing Patkai	Rainforest of upper Assam, notified 2021. Hoolock, hollong trees.
Raimona	Western Assam, 2021. Golden langur country, next to Bhutan.

Ranges at Kaziranga: Kohora (central), Bagori (west, often best for rhino), Agaratoli (east, birds), Burapahar (hills, gibbon).

IF A SPARE MORNING FROM DURRUNG

Nameri is the close one — Jia Bharali, hornbills, a different forest from Kaziranga's grass. Orang is a smaller rhino park on the north bank. Ask the estate; do not freelance a gate.

In any park: muted clothes, no playback of animal calls, no litter, no getting down where you were not asked. The jeep is a hide, not a throne.

PARKS I TOUCHED, OR ONLY PASSED

LIVING THINGS

Flora and fauna

This is monsoon forest, flood grassland, river, and tea. Kaziranga's "big five" are the greater one-horned rhinoceros, Asian elephant, wild water buffalo, swamp deer (barasingha) and tiger. The western hoolock gibbon — India's only ape — sings from canopy south of the Brahmaputra. Gangetic dolphins still roll in the river. In November, migratory waterbirds arrive on the beels.

FAUNA TO WATCH FOR

Greater one-horned rhino
Asian elephant · wild buffalo
Swamp deer · hog deer · sambar
Tiger · leopard · wild boar
Hoolock gibbon · capped langur
Gangetic dolphin · otter
Great Indian hornbill
Greater adjutant stork
Bar-headed goose · whistling duck
Pied kingfisher · fish-eagle

FLORA

Hollong — state tree
Kopou phul — foxtail orchid, state flower
Nahor · simul · bamboo · cane
Elephant grass · water hyacinth
Tea · outenga · thekera · rice



I SAW, AND I MISSED

CLOTH OF THE VALLEY

Assamese handloom



Assam weaves three silks. **Muga** is the golden one, from the moth *Antheraea assamensis*, almost unique to this valley — it deepens with wear. **Eri** (endi) is the warm, wool-like silk; the moth is allowed to leave the cocoon, so it is often called ahimsa silk. **Pat** is the white mulberry silk. Sualkuchi, on the north bank near Guwahati, is the weaving town.

The woman's dress is the mekhela chador — a wrap skirt and a drape — often in muga or pat with red geometric borders. The gamosa, white cotton with a red woven end, is towel, gift, honour, and flag of feeling. The jaapi is the wide bamboo hat of the fields. A gamosa offered to you is not a souvenir first. It is a welcome.

SAW · WORE · WAS GIVEN

COLOUR, WEAVE, WHO MADE IT

THE YEAR IN THREE BIHUS

Annual festivals



Rongali / Bohag	Mid-April. Assamese new year. The great one: dance, dhol, pepa (buffalo horn), new clothes, the spring.
Kati / Kongali	Mid-October. Quiet, lamps in the paddy (saki). You have just missed it in November.
Magh / Bhogali	Mid-January. Harvest feast, community fire (meji), uruka night, feasting.

Other days you may hear of: Ambubachi Mela at Kamakhya in June; Raas at the satras of Majuli in autumn; Ali-Aye-Ligang of the Mishing in February. Bihu is not only a performance. It is the calendar the valley still keeps.

TRACE OF A FESTIVAL I NOTICED — SONG, LAMP, CLOTH, FOOD

A BIHU STEP, A DRUM, A HORN I WANT TO REMEMBER

CAMELLIA SINENSIS VAR. ASSAMICA

About tea



Left alone, tea is a tree. In Assam it is trained as a low bush with a flat **plucking table**. The harvest is the young shoot: **two leaves and a bud**. Durrung has done this since 1864, across 1,400 acres.

Pruning	December–January, when the bush is dormant. A 2–4 year cycle in the plains. Between prunes, a light cut called skiffing keeps the table.
Harvest	Plucking rounds every week or so, March to November. Fine plucking = two leaves and a bud. Coarser plucking makes stronger, rougher tea.
Flushes	First flush (Mar–Apr) is lighter. Second flush (May–Jun) is the famous malty Assam, often with golden tips. Then rains, then autumn.
November	Late season. Some sections still plucked; others heading toward prune. Ask what the bushes are doing this week.

TYPES YOU MAY BE POURED

Orthodox black — whole or broken leaf, rolled, oxidised; aroma and malt. **CTC** — crush, tear, curl; strong, brisk, the everyday chai leaf. **Green / white / oolong** — less oxidation; some estates now make them for tasting. **Second-flush golden tips** — the prize cup if they have it.

Factory steps, orthodox: wither → roll → oxidise → dry → sort. CTC skips the gentle roll.

WHAT THEY WERE PRUNING OR PLUCKING AT DURRUNG

CUPS I TASTED, IN ORDER

A LITTLE OF THE LANGUAGE

Assamese to learn

Assamese (Axomiya) uses the Bengali–Assamese script. English and Hindi will carry you at the hotel. A few words will carry you further. Tick when you have said them out loud.

নমস্কাৰ	Nomoskar	*hello*
আপুনি কেনেকুৱা আছে?	Apuni kenekuwa ase?	*how are you?*
মই ভাল আছোঁ	Moi bhal asu	*I am fine*
মোৰ নাম ...	Mor naam ...	*my name is ...*
ধন্যবাদ	Dhanyabad	*thank you*
মাফ কৰিবা	Maaph koriba	*sorry / excuse me*
ভাত খাইছানে?	Bhaat khaisa ne?	*have you eaten?*
একাপ চাহ দিব	Ekap sah diba	*please give a cup of tea*
পানী দিয়ক	Paani diyok	*please give water*
কি এইটো?	Ki eitu?	*what is this?*
বহুত ভাল	Bohut bhal	*very good*
ভাল লাগিল	Bhal lagil	*I liked it / nice to meet you*

WORDS I PICKED UP

word	*meaning*
word	*meaning*
word	*meaning*

THE SENTENCE I ACTUALLY USED

THE GOING

Vizag to the gardens

Two hops, then a long green road. Record the unremarkable bits. They become the trip.

FLIGHT ONE · VTZ → BBI

NO. _____ SEAT _____

DEP _____ ARR _____

SKY / AIRPORT _____

FLIGHT TWO · BBI → GAU

NO. _____ SEAT _____

DEP _____ ARR _____

FIRST GLIMPSE OF ASSAM FROM THE AIR _____

PICKUP · LOKPRIYA GOPINATH BORDOLOI, GUWAHATI

DRIVER / VEHICLE _____ LEFT AT _____

ARRIVED DURRUNG _____ KM _____

WHAT THE ROAD SHOWED ME

PACK BEFORE YOU LEAVE · NOVEMBER

- ☐ Neutral layers (olive, khaki)
- ☐ Closed shoes
- ☐ Camera + spare battery
- ☐ Hat, sunscreen, insect repellent
- ☐ Light rain shell
- ☐ Warm layer for 5 a.m. safari
- ☐ Binoculars
- ☐ ID for safari permit
- ☐ This journal + pencil
- ☐ Cash for the road

THE STAY · THREE NIGHTS

The Postcard · Durrung

Working estate since 1864 · 1,400 acres · twelve rooms. Planter's bungalow or a chang chalet on stilts among the tea.



ROOM · BUNGALOW / CHALET NO.

FIRST CUP AT

HOW THAT FIRST CUP TASTED

DAYS IN THE GARDEN

Day one

MORNING

AFTERNOON

NIGHT

Day two

MORNING

AFTERNOON

NIGHT

Day three

MORNING

AFTERNOON

LEAVING

TEA TASTING

Two leaves and a bud.

DRY LEAF

LIQUOR COLOUR

AROMA

BODY / FINISH

THE CUP I WANT AGAIN

AT THE TABLE

- ☐ Masor tenga
- ☐ Khar / xaak
- ☐ Aloo pitika
- ☐ Pitha / jolpaan
- ☐ Joha or boka saul rice
- ☐ Plantation trail / factory

FAVOURITE PLATE

PEOPLE I MET

THE PARK · UNESCO

Kaziranga

Arranged through the estate. Grass can still be tall in early November — look along the beels and the burnt patches. Neutral clothes. No calling to animals.

SAFARI ONE

DATE / AM · PM

JEEP / ELEPHANT

KOHORA · BAGORI · AGARATOLI · BURAPAHAR

GUIDE / VEHICLE

SAFARI TWO

DATE / AM · PM

JEEP / ELEPHANT

RANGE

GUIDE / VEHICLE

SEEN · TICK IN THE FIELD

- ☐ One-horned rhino
- ☐ Wild water buffalo
- ☐ Hog deer
- ☐ Wild boar
- ☐ Hoolock gibbon
- ☐ Asian elephant
- ☐ Swamp deer
- ☐ Sambar
- ☐ Otter
- ☐ Tiger · lucky day

BIRDS

THE MOMENT I WILL REMEMBER



sketch a horn, a beel, a silhouette in grass

SLOWER NOTES

What the estate kept

Fill this on a quiet afternoon. Pool, library, verandah, or the deck of the chalet.

SOUNDS

MORNING

NOON

NIGHT · THE ESTATE SITS ON AN ELEPHANT CORRIDOR

WEATHER

DAY 1

DAY 2

DAY 3

I DID NOT EXPECT

A LEAF, A STAMP, A SMALL THING PRESSED HERE

tape a tea leaf, a gamosa thread, a boarding pass stub

THE RETURN

Homeward

Estate drop to Guwahati, then the same sky in reverse. Write before the trip becomes a story you tidy.

DURRUNG → GAU

LEFT AT _____ REACHED AIRPORT _____

LAST LOOK AT THE GARDENS _____

GAU → BBI → VTZ

FLIGHT · SEAT _____ FLIGHT · SEAT _____

WHAT I CARRIED BACK THAT IS NOT IN A BAG _____

THREE THINGS I WILL KEEP

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

A NOTE TO MYSELF IN SIX MONTHS

TEA TO PACK

THANK YOU, SAID TO



MADE FOR A NOVEMBER JOURNEY · VISAKHAPATNAM TO ASSAM · DURRUNG · KAZIRANGA